Amitabha, the chanting of whose name could bring release from pain and suffering, has already been referred to. The cult of the goddess Guanyin, a female incarnation of Avalokiteswara, the Bodhisattva of Compassion, is a peculiarly Chinese phenomenon with no parallel in India. Avalokiteswara is regarded as the earthly manifestation of the self-born and eternal Amitabha Buddha. He has the ability to assume any form that may be required to assist beings who are suffering. Prior to the Song dynasty (960–1270 CE), Avalokiteswara is depicted in unmistakably masculine form, but by the eleventh century, the feminine form as a beautiful young woman, Guanyin, became current. Guanyin means ‘one who hears or listens’, and it is this incarnation, conveying infinite compassion and mercy, which became popular throughout China. The cult travelled to Korea, Japan and Vietnam, and with Chinese migrants to South-East Asia. Temples dedicated to Guanyin are spread all over East Asia.

As India was witnessing the decline and eventual eclipse of the Buddhist faith in the new millennium, China became its alternative centre with its own revered masters, preaching new interpretations of the received scriptures and establishing sacred centres of pilgrimage. Whereas in an earlier age, pilgrims and scholars headed to India to seek the authentic faith, it was to China they were now travelling for the same purpose.

~

This history of Buddhist connections between India and China resonates today as a source of both affinity and cultural contestation. Despite being a communist country, China is not averse to using its Buddhist heritage as an instrument of public diplomacy in Buddhist countries. India in turn has sought to do the same, but in somewhat episodic fashion. The grand celebration and international participation in the 2500th anniversary of Buddha’s death in 1956, which was Pandit Nehru’s initiative, has never been seriously followed through. China, meanwhile, has been busy promoting its own places of pilgrimage and Buddhist studies. It has a rich store of Buddhist manuscripts, including in Sanskrit, unmatched anywhere in the world. Much of India’s history and culture lie embedded in these